Markdown in 10 Minutes

Write once. Render everywhere.

Plain text with superpowers. No software needed, no formatting toolbar.

`#` · `**bold**` · `- list` · `` `code` `` · `[link](url)`

Where Is Markdown Used?

Markdown is the quiet language behind most of the tools developers — and creators — use every day.

GitHub

Every README, issue, pull request, and wiki is written in Markdown.

Notion

Type `/` or use Markdown shortcuts — it converts on the fly.

Substack

Writers paste Markdown directly. Clean formatting with zero clicking.

Slack & Discord

Bold, italic, and code blocks all use Markdown syntax.

VS Code

Built-in preview. The editor every developer already has open.

Static Sites

Jekyll, Hugo, Astro — they all turn `.md` files into webpages.

CONCEPT 01

Headers, Bold, and Italic

The three things you'll type in every single document.

YOU TYPE

```
# Big Heading
## Smaller Heading
### Even Smaller

**this is bold**
*this is italic*
**bold *and italic***
```

YOU GET

Big Heading

Smaller Heading

Even Smaller

this is bold

this is italic

bold *and italic*

Rule of thumb: `#` = biggest. The more `#` symbols, the smaller the heading. Stop at `###` for most documents.

CONCEPT 02

Lists and Checkboxes

Unordered lists, numbered lists, and task lists — all from plain characters.

UNORDERED LIST

```
- Apples
- Oranges
- Mangoes

# Use - or * or +
```

ORDERED LIST

```
1. Install Node
2. Clone the repo
3. Run npm install

# Numbers auto-increment
```

TASK / CHECKBOX LIST

```
- [x] Write the draft
- [x] Add screenshots
- [ ] Publish post

# [x] = done [ ] = todo
```

NESTED LIST

```
- Frontend
  - HTML
  - CSS
- Backend

# Indent with 2 spaces
```

CONCEPT 03

Code Blocks

The most important syntax for developers. Inline code and full fenced blocks.

Inline: Wrap with backticks `` ` `` — use for commands, filenames, variable names.
Write `` `npm install` `` → renders as `npm install`

Fenced block: Three backticks, then the language name for syntax highlighting.

python

```
# You write this above your block:
```python
def greet(name):
    return f"Hello, {name}!"
```

Works for: python, javascript, bash, html, css, json...
```

CONCEPT 04

Links and Images

Both use nearly the same syntax — images just add a `!` at the front.

🔗 LINK

[Link text](https://url.com)
[Visit GitHub](https://github.com)

Square brackets = the label you see. Round brackets = where it goes.

🖼️ IMAGE

![Alt text](image.png)
![Logo](./assets/logo.png)

The `!` tells Markdown to show the image, not just link to it.

Memory trick: Think of it as a label in `[ ]` and a destination in `( )`. Images are links that display instead of navigate.

Tables

Tables look intimidating to type — but the pattern is always the same.

```
| Column 1 | Column 2 |
| -------- | -------- |
| Cell A   | Cell B   |
```

The second row of dashes `---` is what tells Markdown "this is a table header."

Syntax	What it does	Rendered result
`| Name | Age |`	Defines columns	Table header row
`| --- | --- |`	Marks the header	Separator (invisible)
`| Julius | 27 |`	Data row	Table body row
`:---`	Left align column	Text hugs the left
`---:`	Right align column	Text hugs the right

Tip: VS Code extensions like *Markdown Table Formatter* auto-align the pipes for you.

PRACTICE

Write Your First README

Every project on GitHub starts with a `README.md`. Here's the template — copy it, fill it in.

```
# Project Name
A short description of what this project does.

## Getting Started
Clone the repo and install dependencies:
```bash
git clone https://github.com/you/project.git
cd project && npm install
```

Features
- [x] Core feature — does the main thing
- [ ] Dark mode (coming soon)

Made by [Your Name](https://yoursite.com)
```

Plain text.

Infinite reach.

You now know everything you need to write clean, professional Markdown — anywhere.

Check out my other tutorials →

More things you can build with AI